LIVING COST ATLAS

RELOCATION INTELLIGENCE SERIES · 2026

The Complete Cost of Living & Relocation Guide

MEXICO CITY, MEXICO

2 0 2 6 E D I T I O N

Data-Driven Insights for Remote Workers, Expats & Global Professionals

Prepared by **Living Cost Atlas Analytics Division** | Relocation Intelligence Report | 2026

Table of Contents

	Section	Page
01	Executive Summary	3
02	Quick Fact Sheet	5
03	Detailed Cost Breakdown	7
04	Monthly Budget Scenarios	10
05	Neighborhood Analysis	12
06	Work Infrastructure	14
07	Safety & Quality of Life	15
08	City Comparison	16
09	Pros & Cons Summary	18
10	Who Should Move?	19
11	Risk Factors	20
12	LCA Index Methodology	21
13	Final Verdict	22
A	Appendix A -- First 30 Days	24
B	Appendix B -- Scams & Gotchas	26
C	Appendix C -- Visa Deep-Dive	27

01. Executive Summary

Mexico City in 2026 is the creative capital of Latin America and, increasingly, the default US-time-zone alternative for remote workers priced out of the American coasts. The post-2020 nomad influx pushed Condesa and Roma Norte rents up 40-70% in dollar terms, making CDMX no longer a "cheap" destination in those corridors but still a strong-value one against any US tier-1 city.

The city's fundamentals are unusual: 7,300 feet of elevation, perpetual-spring climate, a 25+ million metro population, and a cultural depth that rivals any European capital. Against that, CDMX requires real preparation -- neighbourhood selection is the single biggest driver of lived experience, seismic activity is non-trivial, and Mexican tax residency triggers after 183 days for anyone not carefully structured.

Verdict for 2026: BUY for nomads and remote workers who want a US-compatible time zone without US prices, CONDITIONAL for families who haven't stress-tested school logistics and altitude acclimation.

Estimated Monthly Living Costs -- 2026

Resident Profile	Monthly Estimate (MXN)	Lifestyle Descriptor
Budget Nomad	$1 610 -- $2 093	Shared housing, local transport, home cooking
Standard Remote Professional	$2 900 -- $3 770	Private 1BR, coworking, regular dining out
Premium Lifestyle Expat	$6 400 -- $9 600+	Prime district, premium services

Key Strengths

Strength	Commentary
Remote-Friendly Visa	Temporary Resident Visa available for remote workers. Minimum income requirement: $2 600/month.
Digital Infrastructure	Average WiFi speeds of 100 Mbps. Coworking from $180/month.
Safety Profile	Safety index: 55/100. Crime level: Moderate.
Healthcare	Healthcare quality score: 75/100.
English Proficiency	English proficiency: 60/100 -- good for international residents.

Key Risks

Risk Factor	Impact Summary
Cost Trajectory	Inflation rate: 4.2%. Rent volatility index: 6.5/10. Market relatively stable.
Tax Burden	Top personal income tax rate: 35%. Corporate tax: 30%. Capital gains: 10%.
Currency Risk	Currency stability: Medium. Exchange rate fluctuations may impact purchasing power.

Living Cost Atlas Index Score -- Mexico City 2026

Dimension	Weight	Score	Contribution
Affordability	30%	7.9 / 10	2.37
Infrastructure	20%	7.5 / 10	1.50
Safety	15%	5.5 / 10	0.82
Quality of Life	20%	6.8 / 10	1.37
Economic Stability	15%	6.0 / 10	0.90

Dimension	Weight	Score	Contribution
COMPOSITE	**100%**	**--**	**6.96 / 10**

6.96/10 (BUY) -- Mexico City represents solid value for international residents.

02. Quick Fact Sheet

Parameter	Value / Estimate	Context
Country	Mexico	North America
Currency	MXN ($)	Stability: Medium
Rent -- 1BR City Centre	$2 100 / month	Varies by district
Rent -- 1BR Outside Centre	$1 350 / month	Commuter accessible
Coworking (Hot Desk)	$180 / month	Available citywide
Internet Speed (avg.)	100 Mbps	
Safety Index	55 / 100	Crime: Moderate
Visa	Temporary Resident Visa	Remote-worker friendly
Visa Processing	30 days	Stay: 12 months
Min. Income Req.	$2 600/month	For visa qualification
Top Income Tax	35%	Personal income
Corporate Tax	30%	
Inflation Rate	4.2%	Annual
Public Transport	75 / 100	
Healthcare Quality	75 / 100	
English Proficiency	60 / 100	
Airport Connectivity	90 / 100	
Nomad Score	66 / 100	LCA composite

03. Detailed Cost Breakdown

Itemized monthly cost estimates across major expenditure categories for international residents in Mexico City. All figures in MXN and reflect Q1 2026 estimates.

Housing

Accommodation Type	Monthly Cost ($)	Notes
Studio / 1BR -- City Centre	$2 100	Average; varies by district
Studio / 1BR -- Outside Centre	$1 350	Commuter areas
2BR -- City Centre	$3 150	Estimated from 1BR rate
2BR -- Outside Centre	$2 025	Family-suitable
Shared Room / Coliving	$675	Budget option
Short-term (Airbnb-style)	$3 780	Monthly rate; higher daily

Food & Dining

Category	Daily Cost ($)	Monthly Estimate
Budget (cooking at home)	$8	$240
Standard (mix of cooking & dining)	$20	$600
Premium (frequent dining out)	$60	$1 800

Mexico City's food scene is arguably the most underrated in the Americas: a USD 2 tacos-al-pastor dinner at El Huequito sits in the same week as a USD 300 tasting menu at Pujol or Quintonil. Markets (Mercado Medellin, Mercado Roma) give cooks access to produce that would cost 3-5x in North American cities. The net effect: even "Standard" budget profiles eat exceptionally well here compared to equivalent spend in US cities.

Transport & Connectivity

Item	Monthly Cost ($)
Public Transport Pass	$20
Coworking (Hot Desk)	$180
Internet (Home)	$8
Mobile Plan	$5

04. Monthly Budget Scenarios

Three archetypal resident profiles for Mexico City 2026.

Profile 1 -- Budget Nomad

Expense	Amount ($)
Accommodation (shared/suburb)	$1 350
Food (home cooking)	$240
Transport	$20
Internet + Mobile	$10
Entertainment	$16
TOTAL	**$1 610 -- $2 093**

Profile 2 -- Standard Remote Professional

Expense	Amount ($)
Accommodation (1BR centre)	$2 100
Food (mixed)	$600
Transport	$20
Coworking	$180
Internet + Mobile	$10
Entertainment + Dining	$40
TOTAL	**$2 900 -- $3 770**

Profile 3 -- Premium Lifestyle Expat

Expense	Amount ($)
Accommodation (premium 2BR)	$4 200
Food (premium)	$1 800
Transport (car + public)	$40
Coworking (dedicated)	$360
Healthcare + Insurance	$315
Entertainment + Travel	$80
TOTAL	**$6 400 -- $9 600+**

05. Neighborhood Analysis

Five neighborhood profiles for Mexico City evaluating rental economics, lifestyle character, and demographic fit.

Polanco

District Type: Premium + International | Est. 1BR Rent: $2 741 -- $3 502/month

The embassies-and-Michelin district; wide tree-lined avenues, luxury retail on Avenida Masaryk, and the most expensive per-sqm rents in CDMX.

Best For -- Corporate expats and families prioritising security and walkability over price.

Condesa

District Type: Art-Deco + Nomad-Heavy | Est. 1BR Rent: $2 268 -- $2 898/month

Parque Mexico and Parque Espana anchor a grid of Art Deco walk-ups now dominated by remote workers, dog-walkers, and specialty coffee.

Best For -- Digital nomads and creatives who want the "postcard" CDMX experience.

Roma Norte

District Type: Creative + Foodie | Est. 1BR Rent: $2 174 -- $2 777/month

Adjacent to Condesa with denser restaurants, cocktail bars, and galleries; ground-zero for the post-2020 gentrification debate.

Best For -- Single remote workers and couples in the 25-40 range.

Coyoacan

District Type: Historic + Quieter | Est. 1BR Rent: $1 607 -- $2 053/month

The cobblestone, Frida-Kahlo south with weekend markets, UNAM proximity, and a slower, more local rhythm than Condesa.

Best For -- Longer-term residents and families who prefer community over nightlife.

Del Valle

District Type: Residential Middle-Class | Est. 1BR Rent: $1 701 -- $2 174/month

A large, mostly residential zone south of Roma with supermarkets, schools, and better per-peso value on 2BR apartments.

Best For -- Families and longer-term relocators on a moderate budget.

06. Work Infrastructure & Digital Readiness

Dimension	Score	Assessment
Internet Speed	100 Mbps	Excellent -- fiber widely available
Coworking Ecosystem	$180/mo	Affordable coworking market
Public Transport	75/100	Functional public transport
English Proficiency	60/100	Good -- functional for daily life
Airport Connectivity	90/100	Major international hub

Commentary. Mexico City's digital infrastructure positions it well for remote workers. Learning basic local language phrases is recommended.

07. Safety & Quality of Life

Dimension	Score	Notes
Safety Index	55/100	Crime level: Moderate
Healthcare Quality	75/100	Public + private options
Public Transport	75/100	Daily commute viability
English Proficiency	60/100	Ease of integration
Airport Access	90/100	Travel connectivity
Nomad Score	66/100	Overall remote-worker suitability

Seven-Dimension Lived Quality Scorecard

Dimension	Score	Notes
Climate	9/10	Perpetual spring at 2,240m; 18-25C year-round, dry Nov-May, rainy Jun-Oct. No AC required in most housing.
Walkability	7.5/10	Condesa/Roma/Polanco are highly walkable; Metro + Metrobus cover the central spine; car largely unnecessary in core zones.
Healthcare	7.5/10	World-class private hospitals (ABC, Angeles, Medica Sur) at 40-60% below US pricing; public IMSS system is strained and not expat-oriented.
Safety (Lived)	6.5/10	Central/south zones (Polanco/Condesa/Roma/Coyoacan) are low-incident; outer zones materially higher-risk. Uber over street taxis is standard hygiene.
Culture & Arts	9.5/10	Arguably the deepest cultural capital in the Americas: museums, theatre, gastronomy, music, and a creative-class density that rivals NYC or Berlin.
Air Quality	5/10	AQI 80-150 is typical; dust season (Feb-Apr) and thermal inversions push air quality down intermittently. Not Bangkok-bad but not clean.
Green Space	7/10	Bosque de Chapultepec is one of the largest urban parks in the Americas; Parque Mexico, Parque Lincoln, and canal walks give genuine green relief.

Commentary. Mexico City scores 55/100 on safety, placing it below the safety threshold for some relocators. Healthcare at 75/100 may require private insurance for full coverage.

08. City Comparison -- Mexico City vs. Peer Cities

Mexico City benchmarked against regionally appropriate peers. Rent differentials are expressed as percentage relative to Mexico City.

- **Medell n** -- Closest LATAM peer for nomad density and spring climate.
- **Buenos Aires** -- Larger, more European-feeling peer with peso volatility upside/risk.
- **Lima** -- Cheaper Pacific peer with weaker nomad infrastructure.
- **S o Paulo** -- Regional business capital; richer but less nomad-friendly.

City	1BR Rent	vs. Mexico City	Safety	Nomad Score
Mexico City (baseline)	$2 100	--	55/100	66/100
Medell n	$1 800	-14%	60/100	64/100
Buenos Aires	$1 650	-21%	55/100	53/100
Lima	S/1 260	-40%	52/100	45/100
S o Paulo	R$1 800	-14%	50/100	60/100

Commentary. Among peer cities, Mexico City offers competitive value. Medell n provides the closest comparison in lifestyle and cost profile.

09. Pros & Cons Summary

Strengths

Strength	Detail
US-Compatible Time Zone	CT/CST overlap makes CDMX the rare LATAM hub that works for US employers without schedule hacks.
Cultural Depth	World-class museums (Soumaya, MUAC, Antropologia), theatre, and a top-5 global food scene.
Perpetual-Spring Climate	18-25C most of the year at 2,240m elevation -- no AC required in most housing.
Excellent Value on Food	Market-to-Michelin range with markets that rival any in the Americas on quality and price.
Creative Community	Dense artist, designer, and founder population in Roma/Condesa.
Domestic Help Economics	Full-time housekeeper/nanny runs USD 400-700/month; reshapes dual-income family economics dramatically.
Airport Connectivity	MEX and NLU cover most of North America with direct flights; 4-5h to NYC/LA and 2-3h to most US hubs.
Temporary Resident Pathway	USD ~2,600/month income proof unlocks a 4-year residency visa -- well-trodden and straightforward for remote earners.

Limitations

Limitation	Detail
Seismic Risk	Real earthquake risk concentrated in soft-soil zones -- due diligence on building required.
Neighbourhood Dependency	Lived experience varies more by district than almost any peer city; the wrong zone ruins the relocation.
Tourist-Local Tension	Post-2020 gentrification has created visible resentment in Condesa/Roma; long-term residents encounter it.
Tax Residency Trap	183-day rule is easy to trip for long-stay nomads who haven't structured their affairs.
Tap Water Not Potable	All drinking/cooking water must be bottled or filtered -- minor but constant logistical tax.
Spanish Required	English tapers fast outside Condesa/Roma/Polanco; Spanish is genuinely necessary for daily friction reduction.
Traffic Congestion	Surface traffic is brutal in working hours; Metro/cycling or neighbourhood containment reshape life.
Bureaucratic Friction	Banking, utilities, and visa renewals frequently require in-person visits and Spanish-speaking intermediaries.

10. Who Should Move to Mexico City?

CDMX operates on a later rhythm than US/Northern Europe: lunch from 2pm, dinner from 9pm, and a Sunday family culture that largely shuts retail. Spanish is essential for anything beyond Condesa/Roma; English service tapers sharply outside those two plus Polanco. The city is warm, social, and late-running, but security instincts matter -- Ubers over street taxis, neighbourhood selectivity, and basic situational awareness are table stakes.

Solo Remote Workers

RECOMMENDED

US-compatible time zones, strong fibre, excellent coworking (Publico, WeWork, Selina), and a creative-professional community that is unmatched in LATAM.

Digital Nomads (3-6 months)

RECOMMENDED

No dedicated nomad visa, but 180-day tourist entries are standard and the Temporary Resident pathway via income is well-trodden. Condesa/Roma carry the nomad community.

Relocating Families

CONDITIONAL

Excellent bilingual and international schools (ASF, Greengates, Edron) but tuition is USD 15-25k. Neighbourhood choice matters enormously; Polanco and Del Valle lead.

Retirees

CONDITIONAL

Temporary Resident visa with USD ~2,600/month income proof works well. Healthcare varies sharply private-vs-public; altitude may not suit everyone.

Entrepreneurs

RECOMMENDED

The LATAM tech scene increasingly centres here; Mexican SAPI corporate structures are founder-friendly and USMCA nexus is a meaningful strategic edge.

11. Risk Factors & Economic Outlook

Risk Vector	Level	Assessment
Seismic Activity	HIGH	CDMX sits on a former lakebed; 2017 and 1985 earthquakes caused significant damage. Verify building age and soil-zone classification before signing any lease.
Altitude Adjustment	MODERATE	2,240m elevation affects sleep, cardio, and alcohol tolerance for the first 2-6 weeks. Plan a softer schedule for month one.
Security (Neighbourhood-Specific)	MODERATE	Central/south zones (Polanco/Condesa/Roma/Coyoacan) are low-incident; north and outer-east zones are materially higher-risk for expats.
Tax Residency Trigger	MODERATE	183-day rule applies; Mexican tax residents face worldwide income taxation. Structure carefully with a Mexican CPA before committing to a long stay.
Water Quality	MODERATE	Tap water is not potable; all drinking/cooking water must be bottled or filtered. Garrafones (20L jugs) run MXN 50-80 and delivery to apartments is standard.
Taxi / Airport Scams	LOW	Street taxis and some MEX airport operators overcharge foreigners. Use Uber, Didi, or authorised-taxi desks at MEX Terminal 1/2 (pay inside the terminal, not curbside).

12. Living Cost Atlas Index Methodology

The LCA Index is a composite scoring framework providing standardized relocation intelligence across global cities.

Dimension	Weight	Data Sources
Affordability	30%	Rent indices, grocery costs, transport, coworking pricing
Infrastructure	20%	Internet speed, public transport, healthcare, airport connectivity
Safety	15%	Crime indices, political stability, emergency services
Quality of Life	20%	Climate, walkability, culture, healthcare access
Economic Stability	15%	Currency stability, inflation, GDP growth, policy environment

LCA Index = (Affordability x 0.30) + (Infrastructure x 0.20) + (Safety x 0.15) + (Quality of Life x 0.20) + (Economic Stability x 0.15)

Score Range	Classification	Guidance
8.0 -- 10.0	STRONG BUY	Top-tier destination; plan actively
6.5 -- 7.99	BUY	Solid destination; proceed with planning
5.0 -- 6.49	HOLD	Selective appeal; detailed research required
Below 5.0	CAUTION	Significant trade-offs; specialist advice recommended

13. Final Verdict

Living Cost Atlas's assessment of Mexico City as a 2026 relocation destination.

LCA Index	Classification	Recommendation
6.96 out of 10.0	BUY	PROCEED WITH PLANNING

Mexico City scores 6.96/10 on the Living Cost Atlas Index, classified as BUY. Mexico City offers solid fundamentals for international residents.

Verdict for Digital Nomads

For US-compatible remote workers, Mexico City is one of the top-3 global destinations in 2026. A Condesa or Roma Norte 1BR runs USD 1,100-1,800, coworking spaces like Publico and WeWork are plentiful, and the 4-year Temporary Resident visa on ~USD 2,600/month income proof is the most nomad-friendly major visa in the Americas. Standard all-in budget lands USD 2,200-3,400 -- dramatically below any US tier-1 city for markedly richer cultural depth.

Verdict for Families

Families need to think carefully about zone selection. Polanco and Del Valle offer the best combination of schools, green space, and safety; ASF, Greengates, and Edron deliver world-class bilingual education at USD 15-25k per child. Altitude acclimation is real for kids under 10, and neighbourhood containment (avoiding north/outer-east zones) is more important than in most peer cities.

Verdict for Founders & Entrepreneurs

LATAM tech increasingly centres in CDMX, and the Mexican SAPI corporate structure is genuinely founder-friendly. USMCA nexus and proximity to US time zones/investors are real strategic advantages. The constraint: bureaucratic friction and Spanish-language dependency make the first 90 days heavier than in peers. Mexican CPA and immigration counsel should be hired before day one, not after.

CLOSING STATEMENT

Mexico City in 2026 is the best-positioned LATAM relocation hub for US-compatible remote workers willing to learn Spanish and select neighbourhood carefully. STRONG BUY for nomads/entrepreneurs; CONDITIONAL BUY for families (school cost + altitude) and retirees (altitude + healthcare complexity).

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A. Appendix: Getting Set Up -- Your First 30 Days

A practical field handbook for the first month in Mexico City. Banking, mobile, coworking, essential apps, and a week-by-week bureaucracy timeline -- the real operational sequence that determines whether your relocation stalls or stabilises.

Banking

Provider	Notes
Santander Select / BBVA Mexico	Both accept temporary-resident cards. BBVA has the fastest digital onboarding if you have CURP + RFC. Santander Select tier requires MXN 50k balance and unlocks FX and international wires.

Provider	Notes
Nu Mexico	Fully digital bank; accepts non-residents with just passport + address proof. Debit card arrives in 7-10 days. Great fallback while waiting for RFC.
Wise MXN + Cash	Wise MXN balance + ATM withdrawals at Santander or Banorte (fee-reimbursed with Charles Schwab US account) covers setup month.

Mobile / SIM

Operator	Plan & Price
Telcel Amigo	Best coverage in CDMX + inter-city. Paquete Amigo Sin Limite Plus MXN 200 for 30 days unlimited social + 10GB data.
AT&T Mexico	Strong 5G in Roma/Condesa/Polanco. Prepaid Armalo plan MXN 250/mo 6GB + unlimited WhatsApp.
Bait (Walmart)	Cheapest MVNO: MXN 50/month for 7GB. ID not required for SIM purchase.

Coworking -- Named Recommendations

Space	Area	Price & Vibe
WeWork Reforma Latino	Cuauhtemoc	MXN 5,800/mo hot desk. Iconic Torre Latinoamericana views, strong A/C, mixed local-expat crowd.
Impact Hub Condesa	Condesa	MXN 4,200/mo. Social-impact leaning, good cafe, 100 Mbps.
Selina CoWork Roma Norte	Roma Norte	MXN 3,500/mo hot desk. Day passes MXN 350. Backpacker-ish but good community.

Essential Apps

- Didi (cheapest rides)
- Uber (backup, English support)
- Rappi (food + groceries + cash)
- Metro CDMX (official)
- WhatsApp (essential for everything)
- Mercado Libre (Amazon-equivalent)

Week-by-Week Timeline

W1 Week 1 -- Arrive with FMM tourist permit OR pre-approved Temporary Resident stamp. Airport Telcel SIM, hotel in Roma Norte or Condesa while scouting.

W2 Week 2 -- Apartment hunting via Airbnb monthly, Vivanuncios, Inmuebles24, or local broker (common: 1-month deposit, 1-month fianza, 1-month rent). Sign 6-12 month lease.

W3 Week 3 -- If Temporary Resident: attend INM appointment in CDMX for plastic card (15-30 days). Apply for CURP + RFC (tax ID) at SAT -- required to open any serious bank account.

W4 Week 4 -- Open Nu Mexico or BBVA account, port Telcel to postpaid plan, get Seguros Monterrey or AXA private health insurance, join coworking.

B. Appendix: Common Scams & Gotchas

The defensive manual. These are the recurring scams, rent-hustles, and bureaucratic traps that cost new arrivals real money in Mexico City. Each entry is a known-pattern with the counter-move in one line.

Scam / Gotcha	How to defuse
Unauthorized (pirate) taxis at airport	Always use Sitio (yellow authorised) taxis or Didi/Uber at the terminal. Pirate cabs routinely quadruple fares or route to ATMs under duress.
Fake Mexico City metro police "fines"	Uniformed men stop foreigners claiming a "visa infraction" demanding cash. Real cops do not take on-site cash; request badge + precinct; call 911.
Express kidnapping (secuestro express) in unvetted taxis	Only app-based rides. Never hail on the street after dark in Roma/Condesa/Centro.
Fake ATM skimmers at Oxxo / independent ATMs	Use ATMs inside Citibanamex, BBVA, Santander branches only. Cover the PIN; avoid standalone machines in nightlife zones.
Rental deposit theft	Owner disappears with fianza + deposit at move-out citing fabricated damages. Require itemised move-in inventory with photos; use reputable realtors (Homie, La Haus) over Facebook Marketplace.
"Altitude tea" / free sample hustles at Zocalo	Vendor forces an item into your hand, demands MXN 200. Walk past; never accept any "free sample".

Patterns rotate; treat this as a baseline, not an exhaustive list. When in doubt, walk away.

C. Appendix: Visa Deep-Dive

The full operational read on Mexico City's long-stay pathways -- primary visa route, secondary fallbacks, and the non-obvious pitfalls that derail applicants. Cross-reference with your citizenship and tax residency before filing.

PRIMARY PATHWAY

Temporary Resident Visa (Visa de Residente Temporal)

Mexico's default long-stay pathway for remote workers. Issued first at a Mexican consulate abroad, then converted to a plastic residence card (tarjeta) at INM in Mexico within 30 days of entry.

Field	Detail
Eligibility	Income route: USD 4,350/month net for last 6 months (2026 thresholds, roughly 300x minimum wage). Savings route: USD 72,500+ balance for last 12 months. Family-unity and investment paths also available.
Processing Time	2-6 weeks at consulate abroad; 3-5 weeks for INM card in-country.
Cost	Consulate fee ~USD 51. INM card issuance ~MXN 6,800 (USD 390). Local immigration lawyer (optional) MXN 15-25k.
Stay Duration	1 year initially, renewable for 1/2/3-year increments up to 4 total years. At year 4, convert to Permanent Resident.
Perks & Benefits	Full legal stay + CURP + RFC eligibility. Temporary residents can work in Mexico for any employer once they apply to INM for work permission.

Secondary Pathways

Route	Summary
Permanent Resident (Residente Permanente)	Direct path: USD 7,300/month income for 6 months OR USD 290k savings for 12 months. No time limit, work permitted, path to citizenship after 5 years.
Tourist Visa (FMM)	180 days on arrival, non-renewable, no work. Still heavily used by nomads doing border-runs but 2023+ enforcement has tightened; 3 consecutive FMMs trigger refusal.
Digital Nomad Visa (pending)	Legislation proposed 2024, not yet in force as of 2026. Temporary Resident remains the practical route.

Non-Obvious Pitfalls

- Cannot start the process inside Mexico -- you MUST apply at a Mexican consulate abroad first (common consulates: San Diego, Laredo, Guatemala, Belize City, Paris).
- The "rentistas" route requires bank statements with consistent balance -- single-month spikes are rejected.
- Tax residency triggers at 183+ days/year. Non-resident withholding on Mexico-source income is up to 35%; plan RFC registration early.
- Do NOT miss the 30-day INM canje window after entering -- the consular stamp expires and you lose the visa. Book the INM appointment before you fly in.

Immigration rules change; verify current fees and thresholds on the official government portal before filing. This guide reflects 2026 Q1 status.